

Principles of Programming Languages

Lecture 5: Semantics

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Outline

Semantics: introduction

An evaluator for IMP

Semantics: motivation

C

```
-$ cat test.c
int main()
{
    int x;
    return (x=1) + (x=2);
}
-$ gcc test.c
-$ ./a.out ; echo $?
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```

Java

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-$ cat File.java
public class File {
    ... void main(...) {
        int x = 0;
        println((x=1) + (x=2));
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Semantics: motivation

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Semantics: motivation

GCC: 5.4.0-6 ubuntu

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GCC: Apple clang 13.1.6

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GCC: Ubuntu 9.4.0

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-$ gcc test.c
-$ ./a.out ; echo $?
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```

Semantics

- ▶ Semantics is concerned with the **meaning** of language constructs
- ▶ Semantics must be **unambiguous**
- ▶ Semantics must be **flexible**

Semantic - informal

Informal semantics (examples): **natural language**

Rationale for the ANSI C Programming Language:

- ▶ “Trust the programmer”
- ▶ “Don’t prevent the programmer from doing what needs to be done”
- ▶ “Keep the language small and simple”
- ▶ “Provide only one way to do an operation”
- ▶ “Make it fast, even if it is not guaranteed to be portable”

Inexact! – could lead to **undefined behavior** in programs

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Formal Semantics

Some (formal) semantics styles:

- ▶ operational
- ▶ denotational
- ▶ axiomatic

We will focus more on **operational** semantics styles: Small-step SOS, Big-Step SOS

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A simple imperative language

Program:

```
n ::= 10;;  
i ::= 1;;  
sum ::= 0;;  
while (i <= n) do  
    sum ::= sum + ' i;;  
    i ::= i + ' 1  
end
```

Features:

- ▶ variables
- ▶ arithmetic expressions
- ▶ boolean expressions
- ▶ assignment statements
- ▶ loop statements
- ▶ decisional statements

How can we define the semantics of this language?

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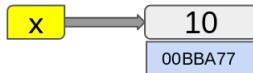
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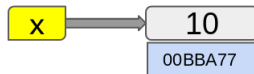
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- ▶ variable = *storage location at address* + *symbolic name*
- ▶ variables can be *accessed* or *modified*
- ▶ depending on the language, they may only be able to store a specified datatype (e.g., integer, string, etc.)
- ▶ *Scope*: global, local
- ▶ *Lifetime (extent)*
- ▶ $var_name \mapsto value$
- ▶ Environment + memory



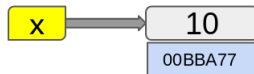
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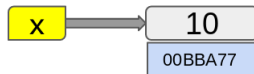
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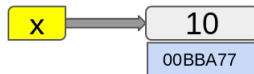
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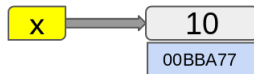
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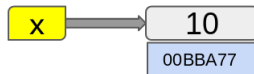
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Environment

- ▶ Environment: variables mapped to values

Definition `Env := string -> nat.`

Definition `env (string : string) :=
if (string_dec string "n")
then 10
else 0.`

- ▶ The environment is just a function

`Compute (env n).`

`= 10`

`: nat`

`Compute (env i).`

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Check `env.`

`env : string -> nat`

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Environment update

- Update = a new function s.t. the value for x is updated to v :

```
Definition update (x : string)
                  (v : nat)
                  (env : Env) : Env :=
fun y => if (string\_dec x y)
then v
else env y.
```

Arithmetic expressions

► Syntax:

BNF:
AExp ::= $\mathbb{N}$
 | AExp '+' AExp
 | AExp '**' AExp

```
Inductive AExp :=  
  | anum : nat -> AExp  
  | aplus : AExp -> AExp -> AExp  
  | amul : AExp -> AExp -> AExp.
```

► Semantics:

```
Fixpoint aeval (a : AExp) : nat :=  
  match a with  
  | anum v => v  
  | aplus a1 a2 => (aeval a1) + (aeval a2)  
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Arithmetic expressions with *variables*

► Syntax:

BNF:
AExp ::= string
 | $\mathbb{N}$
 | AExp '+' AExp
 | AExp '*' AExp

```
Inductive AExp :=  
  | var : string -> AExp  
  | anum : nat -> AExp  
  | aplus : AExp -> AExp -> AExp  
  | amul : AExp -> AExp -> AExp.
```

► Semantics:

```
Fixpoint aeval (a : AExp) : nat :=  
  match a with  
  | var v => ???  
  | anum v => v  
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Evaluate expression with variables

► Semantics:

```
Fixpoint aeval (a : AExp) (env : Env) : nat :=  
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  end.
```

► Notations and testing:

```
Coercion var : string >-> AExp.
```

```
Coercion anum : nat >-> AExp.
```

```
Notation "A + ' B" := (aplus A B) (at level 50).
```

```
Notation "A * ' B" := (amul A B) (at level 40).
```

```
Compute aeval (2 + ' 3 * ' 4) env.
```

```
= 14
```

```
: nat
```

```
Compute env n.
```

```
= 10
```

```
: nat
```

```
Compute aeval (2 + ' 3 * ' n) env.
```

```
= 32
```

```
: nat
```

Boolean expressions

► Syntax:

```
Inductive BExp :=  
  | btrue  : BExp  
  | bfalse : BExp  
  | blessthan : AExp -> AExp -> BExp  
  | band : BExp -> BExp -> BExp  
  | bnot : BExp -> BExp.
```

► Semantics:

```
Fixpoint beval (b : BExp) (env : Env) : bool :=  
  match b with  
    | btrue => true  
    | bfalse => false  
    | blessthan a1 a2 => Nat.leb (aeval a1 env) (aeval a2 env)  
    | band b1 b2 => andb (beval b1 env) (beval b2 env)  
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  end.
```


Assignments

► Syntax:

```
Inductive Stmt :=  
  | assignment : string -> AExp -> Stmt.  
Notation "A ::= B" := (assignment A B) (at level 54).  
Check n ::= 100 .  
n ::= 100  
: Stmt
```

► Assignments modify the environment

► Semantics:

```
Fixpoint eval(s : Stmt) (env : Env) : Env :=  
match s with  
  | assignment x a => update x (aeval a env) env  
end.
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Assignments

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Programs: sequence of statements

► Syntax:

Inductive Stmt :=

| seq s1 s2 => eval s2 (eval s1 env)

Notation "S S'" := (assignment S S') (at level 54).

Check n ::= 100 ;; i ::= 7 .

n ::= 100 ;; x i ::= 7

: Stmt

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Fixpoint eval (s : Stmt) (env : Env) : Env :=

match s **with**

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Loops

- Syntax:

Inductive Stmt :=
| while : BExp -> Stmt -> Stmt.

- Semantics:

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  match s with  
    | while b s' => if (beval b env)  
      then (eval (seq s' (while b s')) env)  
      else env  
  end.
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Error: Cannot guess decreasing argument of fix.

- Solution: define eval as a *relation*!

Loops

- Syntax:

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Evaluation as a relation

► **Assignment:**
$$\frac{\text{aeval } a \ E = v}{(\text{eval } (x ::= a) \ E \ (x \mapsto v ; E))}$$

► **Sequence:**
$$\frac{\text{eval } s_1 \ E_1 \ E' \quad \text{eval } s_2 \ E' \ E_2}{(\text{eval } (\text{seq } s_1 \ s_2) \ E_1 \ E_2)}$$

► **Loop (true case):**

$$\frac{\text{beval } b \ E_1 = \text{true} \quad \text{eval } s \ E_1 \ E' \quad \text{eval } (\text{while } b \ s) \ E' \ E_2}{(\text{eval } (\text{while } b \ s) \ E_1 \ E_2)}$$

► **Loop (false case):**
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